

Vibe Appliance — Setup

Install your firm's Vibe server: one machine, every Vibe app, recoverable by design.

Vibe Appliance setup guide · built 2026-08-31 · condensed from docs/INSTALL.md · KisaesDevLab/Vibe-Appliance

1. What you are setting up

The Vibe Appliance is a single Linux server that runs your firm's Vibe stack — Trial Balance, MyBooks, Connect, Tax-Research, Payroll & Time, Practice Management, and the rest — plus the supporting infrastructure (database, cache, TLS, backup, monitoring). One install. One server. No fleet.

You need to be able to copy a command into a terminal and to know your firm's domain name. You do not need to have used Docker before. Day-to-day operation after the install happens entirely in a browser.

The design promise: every step can be re-run safely. If an install fails halfway, fix the thing the error message names and run the same command again — it picks up where it stopped. Every error the appliance prints includes a recovery hint.

2. Pick a mode

MODE	BEST FOR	YOU NEED
Domain	The firm's web-facing install	A domain name you own; ideally a free Cloudflare account
LAN	A physical box in the office, internal-only	Nothing beyond the office network
Tailscale	Internal-only, reachable from anywhere	A Tailscale account + an authkey

Domain + Tailscale can run together: public for clients, tailnet-only for staff admin. In every mode, all apps share **one hostname** with a path per app — e.g. `https://vibe.firm.com/tb/`, `http://<host>.local/mybooks/`. Enabling more apps never creates DNS work.

3. The quickest path (domain + Cloudflare Tunnel)

Recommended for most firms: no router changes, no port forwarding, real TLS handled by Cloudflare. Seven steps, about 30 minutes including account setup.

1. **Create an Ubuntu 24.04 droplet** at DigitalOcean. Recommended size `s-2vcpu-4gb` (\$24/mo) — runs every app with headroom. (`s-1vcpu-2gb` works for two or three apps.) Note its public IP.

2. **SSH in:** `ssh root@<droplet-ip>`. On Windows, PowerShell's built-in `ssh` works.
3. **Create a Cloudflare API token** (your domain's DNS must be on Cloudflare — free, and your registrar doesn't change). Profile → API Tokens → Create Token → Custom token, with permissions Account → Cloudflare Tunnel → Edit and Zone → DNS → Edit on your zone. Copy it immediately — Cloudflare shows it once.
4. **Run the installer** on the droplet, replacing the two placeholder values:

```
curl -fsSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/KisaesDevLab/Vibe-Appliance/main/bootstrap.sh \
| sudo bash -s -- \
  --mode domain \
  --domain firm.com \
  --tunnel-subdomain vibe \
  --email admin@firm.com
```

It runs eight numbered phases over 5–15 minutes, then prints your console URL and admin password. **Copy the password now** — it also lives in `/opt/vibe/CREDENTIALS.txt` on the server.

5. **Open the admin console** at `https://<droplet-ip>/admin`. Your browser warns about a self-signed certificate — that's expected before the tunnel exists; click through. Username `admin`, paste the password.
6. **Provision the Cloudflare Tunnel:** in the console, Configuration → Network → Cloudflare Tunnel. Paste the API token, let the wizard discover your account and zone, click Use these values, Save, then Provision tunnel now. About 30 seconds later the appliance is live at `https://vibe.firm.com/` with real TLS.
7. **Enable your first app** — see §7 below.

4. The other install commands

Same installer, different flags. Run on the server as root.

LAN mode (the default — no flags)

```
curl -fsSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/KisaesDevLab/Vibe-Appliance/main/bootstrap.sh |
sudo bash
```

Tailscale mode

Generate an authkey at `login.tailscale.com` → Settings → Keys, then:

```
curl -fsSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/KisaesDevLab/Vibe-Appliance/main/bootstrap.sh |
sudo bash -s -- \
  --mode tailscale \
  --tailscale-authkey tskey-auth-XXXXXX
```

Domain mode with your own port forwarding (no tunnel)

If you can forward ports 80/443 to the server, add one DNS A record (`vibe.firm.com` → server IP) and run the domain-mode command from §3 step 4; certificates are issued automatically on the first request. Cloudflare DNS-01, Namecheap DNS-01 and Namecheap Dynamic DNS variants are covered in `docs/INSTALL.md` §2.

If a phase fails: don't re-run blindly. Read the message — it names what failed, the common causes, a diagnose command and a fix. Fix that one thing, then run the same install command again. Re-running is safe and it converges.

5. Setting up from a Windows computer

The appliance itself runs on Ubuntu Linux, never on Windows — but Windows is a perfectly good machine to drive the install from, and most firms will operate it from Windows desktops afterwards. Everything below is built into Windows 10 and 11; there is nothing to buy or download except, optionally, Tailscale.

Running the install from Windows

1. Open **Terminal** (or **PowerShell**) from the Start menu — Windows includes the `ssh` command; you do not need PuTTY.
2. Connect to your server: `ssh root@<droplet-ip>`. The first connection asks whether to trust the host's fingerprint — type `yes`.
3. Copy the install command from §3 or §4 and paste it into the terminal window: **right-click pastes** in the Windows terminal (Ctrl+Shift+V also works — plain Ctrl+V may not). Paste the whole multi-line command in one go; the trailing backslashes make it a single command.
4. Everything you type from here runs on the server — the Windows machine is only the window. When the install finishes, you can close the terminal; the appliance keeps running.

Reaching the appliance from Windows afterwards

- **Domain mode:** open the console URL in Edge or Chrome — real certificate, nothing special to do.
- **LAN mode:** recent Windows 10/11 resolves `<host>.local` names out of the box, but some office networks and VPN clients block that discovery traffic. If the `.local` name doesn't load, use the server's IP address (`http://<server-ip>/admin`). For clean names on the LAN admin surfaces (`cockpit.`, `portainer.`, `backup.`), your IT person can add lines to `C:\Windows\System32\drivers\etc\hosts` (edited as Administrator) pointing those names at the server's LAN IP — the small-office substitute for split-DNS.

- **Tailscale mode:** install the Tailscale app for Windows from `tailscale.com/download` on each staff machine and sign in to the firm's tailnet; the console and app URLs then work from anywhere. The tray icon shows connection state.
- Before the Cloudflare tunnel is provisioned (§3 step 6), the browser warns about a self-signed certificate — expected; click Advanced → Continue. Once the tunnel is up, the warning is gone for the public URL.

Trying it locally on a Windows machine

For a local or test install without a cloud server, run Ubuntu Server 24.04 in a virtual machine on the Windows box (Hyper-V or VirtualBox), give the VM a bridged network connection so it gets its own LAN address, then follow the LAN install inside the VM. Running the appliance directly on Windows or under WSL is not supported.

6. Your credentials

Everything you need is in one root-only file on the server:

```
sudo cat /opt/vibe/CREDENTIALS.txt
```

- **Console URL** — domain mode `https://vibe.firm.com/admin`; LAN `http://<server-ip>/admin`; Tailscale `https://<host>.<tailnet>.ts.net/admin`.
- **Username** `admin` and the 64-character **password** — paste it, don't type it.
- The **Duplicati backup passphrase** — see §8; losing it makes backups unrecoverable.

Store the password and the backup passphrase in your firm's password manager now.

7. Enable apps

1. In the admin console, scroll to **Apps**. Each Vibe app has a card.
2. Click **Enable** — Vibe Trial Balance is the recommended first app.
3. Within ~2 minutes the badge goes `not-installed` → `enabling...` → `running`, and the card shows the live URL. No DNS work is ever needed for a new app.
4. Open the URL, sign in with the credentials from the console's **First-login info** panel, and set a real password when prompted.

Each app card links its own setup guide (PDF) — enabling steps, where to sign in, and the settings that particular app needs.

8. Set up backups before real work

Do this before trusting the appliance with client data. In the console → **Infra services** → **Duplicati (backup)** (reachable from the LAN or Tailscale only — never exposed publicly):

1. Set Duplicati's web password.
2. Add a backup: source paths `/source/vibe-data` and `/source/vibe-env` are already mounted read-only.
3. Destination: an off-site target you own — S3-compatible storage, Backblaze B2, or rsync.net. Don't leave it unset.
4. Encryption passphrase: the `DUPLICATI_PASSPHRASE` value from `/opt/vibe/CREDENTIALS.txt` . **If you lose this passphrase, your backups are unrecoverable.**
5. Schedule nightly. Run one backup manually, then test restoring a single file to a scratch path so you know the recovery path works.

The Apps tab also offers **Vibe Backup** — the suite's own backup system, with deletion-proof off-site storage and a monthly automated restore drill. Enable it and follow its own setup guide (linked on its card); keep the Duplicati job configured alongside it while its per-app coverage rolls out.

9. Daily operation

TASK	HOW
Open the appliance	Visit the console URL
Run diagnostics	Admin → Doctor → Run, or <code>sudo vibe doctor</code>
Read logs	Admin → Logs , or <code>sudo vibe logs <name></code>
Update an app	An update available badge appears on its card → click Update . A database backup is taken first; a failed update rolls back automatically.
Roll back	Click Roll back on the card
Container detail	Portainer (Infra services; LAN/Tailscale only)
Host metrics	Cockpit (Infra services; LAN/Tailscale only)
Update the Linux system	Admin → Host services → Open system updates (Cockpit). The row shows how many updates are pending and whether a reboot is due.

App updates are never automatic — nothing changes until you click. The one exception, on purpose, is Linux security patches: the appliance turns on Ubuntu's unattended security updates at install time, so those land nightly on their own (no automatic reboot; the Host services row tells you when a reboot is due).

10. When something breaks

- **`sudo vibe doctor` is the single best first move.** It checks the host, the core services, every enabled app, DNS and certificates, and prints exactly which check failed and what to do.
- Every error message follows the same shape: what failed → common causes → a diagnose command → a fix command → the next step. Do what it says, in order.
- Re-running the installer is always safe. It repairs a half-finished state rather than damaging a good one.
- `docs/TROUBLESHOOTING.md` in the appliance repository is keyed by symptom, from "console doesn't load" up.
- Disaster path: follow the **restore runbook** (its own PDF, linked from the Apps header — print it and keep it with the Recovery Kit). With Vibe Backup active it is one command on a fresh Ubuntu machine; the Duplicati fallback is the same install command plus a restore of `/opt/vibe/data` and `/opt/vibe/env`.